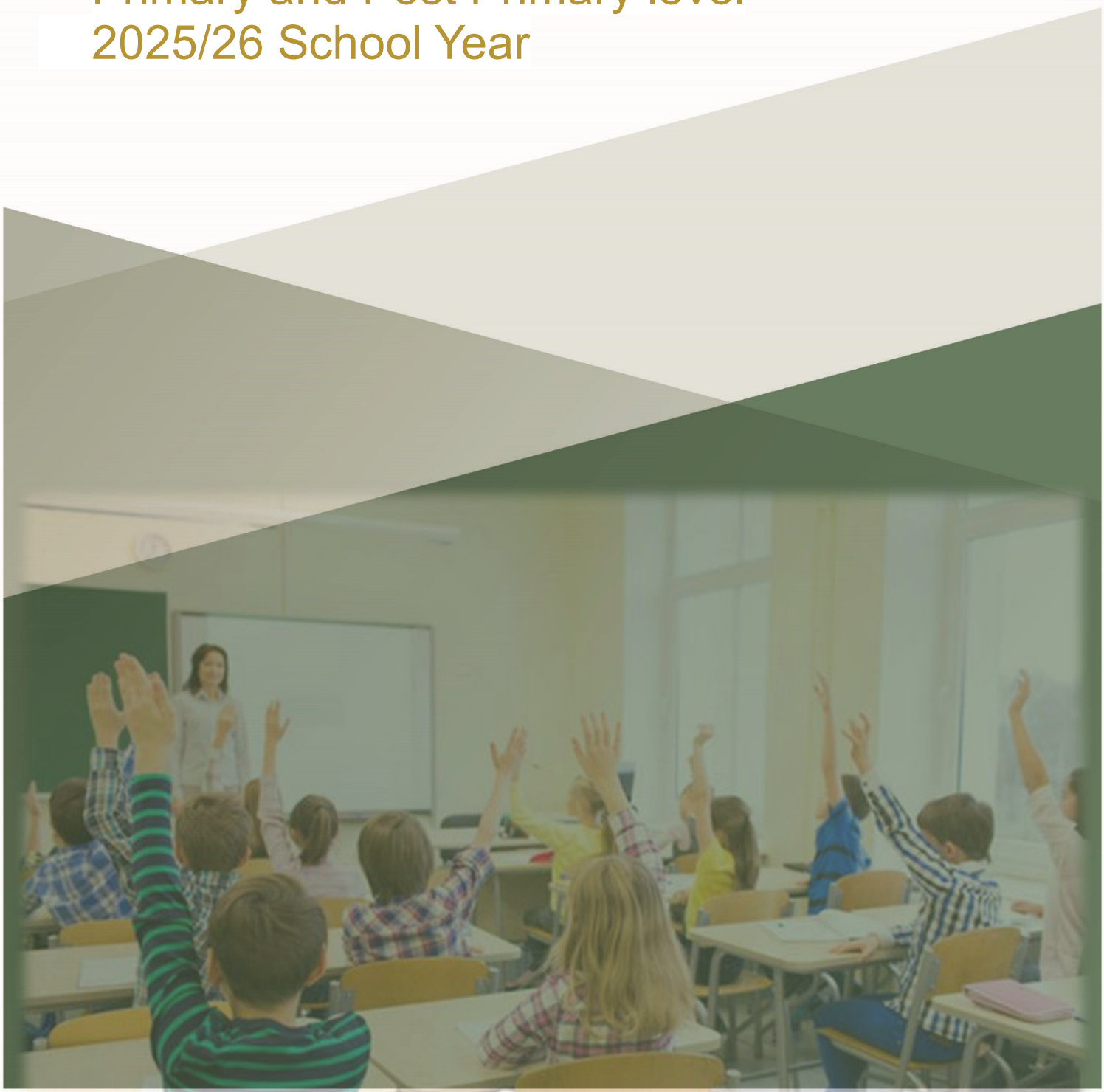
An Roinn Oideachais agus Óige
Department of Education and Youth

The Teaching Workforce in Ireland

Primary and Post Primary level
2025/26 School Year



April 2026

This report and others in the series may be accessed at:

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Introduction

This is the first report in a planned series which will provide an annual statistical summary of the teaching workforce. This will provide a robust evidence base to support education policy makers, researchers and others in the design, delivery, and evaluation of a high-quality education system

The data in this report are produced by the Department of Education and Youth to gain a deeper understanding into trends into the teaching workforce. The main source of the information in this report is pseudonymised data extracted from the payroll systems operating within the Department. The data are also published on the Central Statistics Office Open database, PXStat[1]. The methodology was shared with stakeholders across the sector in December 2025 and was developed in consultation with the Teacher Supply Data Working Group[2].

The salary for most primary and post primary teachers issues every two weeks (on alternating Thursdays) from the Department. This accounts for approximately 86% of the entire employed teaching workforce. The remainder (14%) are paid either monthly, fortnightly, or weekly by the 16 individual Education and Training Boards (ETBs), however, this operation is centralised through the Education Shared Business Services (ESBS) which is provided by the Department.

An extract of payroll records is taken from these systems at a point in time and used to generate statistical information on teachers employed across the education system. These statistics are aggregated by school roll number, county, level (primary, post primary), status (DEIS, Non-DEIS, Special) and so forth – see **Figure 1** below.



Payroll information…

…used to examine records…
• Females, Males
•Contracted hours
•School Roll number, type
etc.

… to generate **statistical** information.

Figure 1 - overview of report methodology.

The statistical information generated and included in this report covers a range of topics, including basic socio-demographic information about the teaching workforce and more detailed statistics on

[1] See EDA100 here - https://data.cso.ie/table/EDA100 and EDA82 here https://data.cso.ie/table/EDA82
[2] More information: https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-education/organisation-information/teacher-supply-data-working-group/)

local areas and trends over time. Additionally, information on current enrolments (which primarily informs the allocation of teaching posts) is provided for context. While data are available at individual school level, data are aggregated and reported at either national, ETB or county level to ensure no individuals are identifiable in any statistical tables. The methodology used in producing this report was shared with human resource (HR) units across various ETBs, and with other stakeholders to verify that the statistical outputs met reasonably the expected levels of the workforce and were found to be robust. Collaboration is currently underway with the Central Statistics Office (CSO) to facilitate the statistics in this report obtaining Irish Statistical System Code of Practice (ISSCOP) certification[3].

Enrolments and class size, 2025/26 school year

Preliminary data shows in September 2025, the beginning of the 2025/26 school year, total enrolments in mainstream primary schools stood at 535,620 pupils, a decrease of 6,759, or 1.2%, on September 2024 (542,379). Total enrolments in post primary schools stood at 429,654 in September 2025, an increase of 4,243 pupils, or 1.0%, on September 2024 (425,411).

The latest data available from August 2025[4] showed average class size[5] at primary level stood at 22.2, down from 24.9 in 2014/15. The Pupil Teacher Ratio (PTR) in primary schools decreased from 16.2 pupils per teacher in 2014/15 to 12.8 pupils per teacher in 2024/25. Class sizes at post primary level are not measured, as it varies by subject, level and class, even within individual schools. The post primary PTR, however, decreased from 13.9 to 12.4 pupils per teacher between 2014/15 and 2024/25, while allocated teaching posts increased by 40.5% and enrolments by 26.6%.

Statistical summary of the workforce at the end of November 2025

The following section contains statistical tables on the workforce for the last payruns in November 2025 (i.e. the last 2 weeks in November). Payroll extracts are taken at various points throughout the year and it was found that the November payroll extract was the most stable, as agreed by the Teacher Supply Data Working Group. The main findings are summarised in **Figure 2** below. The headline figures of the workforce are provided in Tables 1–7 below. The corresponding geographic breakdown is provided Tables 8, 9 and 10.

[3] Further information on ISSCOP certification can be found at: https://www.nationaldata.ie/Standards/ISSCoP/

[4] Statistical Bulletin Overview of Education 2004/05 – 2024/25 – see https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/d65b0730/Statistical_Bulletin.pdf

[5] Average class size is calculated by dividing the number of students enrolled by the number of classes. Pupil Teacher Ratio (PTR) is obtained by dividing the number of full-time equivalent pupils at a given level of education by the number of full-time equivalent teachers.

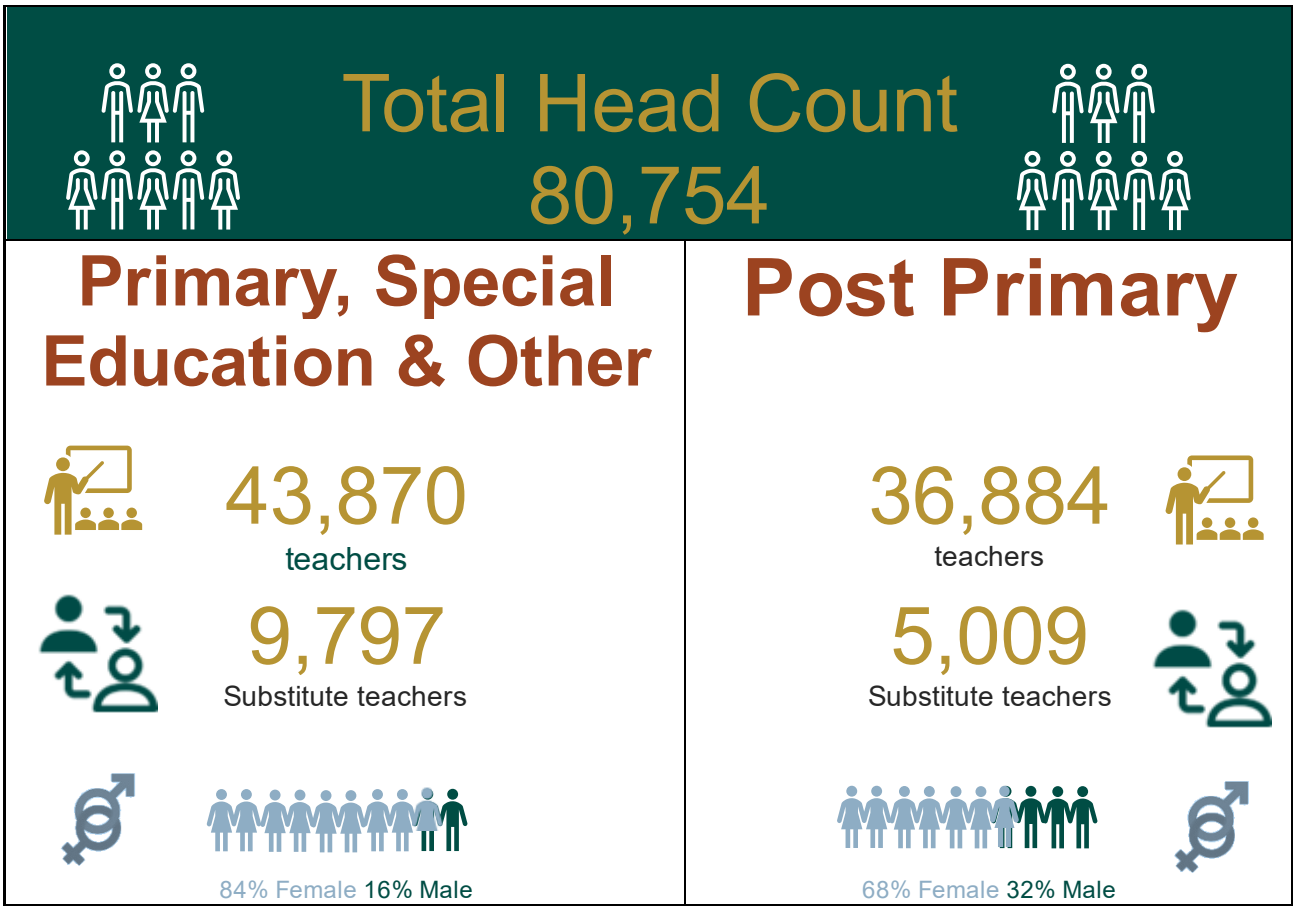


Figure 2 - Summary of workforce, November 2025.

Headline Workforce

The mean conversion rate (MCR) which measures the relationship between the number in the workforce versus the cover they provide at both primary and post primary was approximately 94% in November 2025. That is, each 100 teachers cover 94 Full Time Equivalency (FTE) posts on average. Table 1 summarises the workforce and compares the total FTE to the allocated posts nationally. Where FTE falls short of the allocation, this is collectively termed "unused allocation", where the FTE exceeds the allocation, this is termed "surplus allocation". The values are calculated at school level, and are then aggregated nationally, therefore, include a mixture of unused and surplus allocation – see **information box 1** for more detail on this distinction. Table 2 provides a count of schools that have filled 99% of their FTE allocation and conversely, the count of schools that have unused allocation greater than 1% of their overall allocation, and the number of schools with a partial unused allocation remaining. Together, Tables 1 and 2 provide a measure of the overall strength of the workforce relative to the national target. Table 3 provides the breakdown of school leaders in mainstream primary and post primary schools by gender. In tables 1 to 3, 'Post Primary' includes ETB and Department of Education and Youth post primary schools.

Table 1 - Summary of mainstream school's workforce at primary and post primary levels, Headcount and FTE, November 2025

	Primary	Post Primary	Totals
Head Count	41,729	36,884	78,613
Payroll FTE	39,312	34,626	73,938
Mean Conversion Rate	94.2%	93.9%	94.1%
Allocation FTE	40,308	34,873	75,181
Unused Allocation	996	247	1,243
Cover	97.5%	99.3%	98.3%

Table 2 –Number of schools with used/unused allocation, overall proportion of schools with unused allocation, November 2025

	Number of Schools with < 99% allocated used	Number of Schools with ≥ 99% allocation used	Number of Schools with a partial unused allocation	Proportion of schools with unused allocation
Primary	888	2,179	100	29%
Post Primary	367	354	488	67.7%

Table 3 –Breakdown of school leaders by gender in mainstream schools at Primary and Post Primary levels, November 2025

	Role	% Male	% Female
Primary	Principals	34.4%	65.6%
	Deputy Principals	13.3%	86.7%
Post Primary	Principals	55%	45%
	Deputy Principals	40.8%	59.2%

Information Box 1 – Gross & Net Posts Explained

The statistics in Table 1 represents the "net" allocated posts either in surplus or unused nationally, rather than "gross" posts unused. The measure of gross unused posts would be the sum of all posts unused at school level, whereas the net unused also considers where the workforce is over the allocation in schools. To help users understand the difference, here is a simple example that explains gross versus net posts across 3 fictitious schools:

- School "A" is allocated 10 FTE posts, they have 13 teachers on payroll, 10 of them work 100% patterns, and 3 work a 50% pattern:
    - The total FTE in School A = 11.5
    - The total teachers in School A = 13
    - The MCR in School A is 88.5%
- School "B" is also allocated 10 FTE posts, they have 8 teachers on payroll, all of which work 100% patterns:
    - The total FTE in School B = 8
    - The total teachers in School B = 8
    - The MCR in School B is 100%
- School "C" is also allocated 10 FTE posts, they have 10 teachers on payroll, 9 of which work 100% patterns and 1 works a 50% pattern:
    - The total FTE in School C = 9.5
    - The total teachers in School C = 10
    - The MCR in School C is 95%

The total allocation across all 3 schools is 30 FTE posts.

The total FTE on payroll is 29 (11.5 + 8 + 9.5) and the total number of teachers is 31 (13 + 8 + 10). The MCR across all three schools is 93.5%.

The **gross** deficit across both schools is **-2.5 FTE** (-2.0 in School B and -0.5 in School C).
The **net** deficit is **-1.0 FTE** (-2.0 in School B, - 0.5 in School C, + 1.5 in School A).
The whole-time deficit is 1 (2 full posts in School B unfilled and 1 full post overfilled in School A) and the part-time deficit is 0 (-0.5 from School C and +0.5 in School A).

Workforce in Irish Medium Education and Special Education

This section provides summaries for specific sectors of the education system, namely Irish medium education (Table 4) and special education (Table 5). Table 4 presents data from schools in which all students are taught all subjects through the Irish language. Both ETB and Department of Education and Youth post primary schools are included.

Table 4 – Summary of Workforce employed in Irish Medium Education schools, November 2025

	Primary	Post Primary
Allocation	2,920	1,195
Payroll FTE	2,856	1,245
Cover	97.8%	100%

Table 5 – Summary of Workforce employed in Special Education schools, November 2025

	Payroll FTE	Allocation	Deficit	Cover	Deficit
Special Education Schools	1,871	1,920	49	97.4%	2.6%

Temporary and part-time workforce

The data for substitutes and career breaks utilises claims and leave information across the entire month of November to generate the counts. Measures of part-time and job-sharing teachers use payroll information based on the last pay run in November. The substitutes counted in Table 6 may have worked anywhere from one day to every working day in the month of November.

Table 6 - Count of unique substitutes paid during the month of November.

	Substitutes
Primary	9,797
Post Primary (D/Ed)	5,009
Total	14,806

Table 7- Count of teachers working less than full time, job sharing and availing of career break as of November 2025[6]

	Job Sharers	Part Time (fixed term)	Part Time (Permanent)	Career Breaks
Primary	4,500	731	4,533	2,471
Post Primary (D/Ed)	1,604	880	1,991	845
Post Primary (ETBs)	15	387	1,083	273
Total	6,119	1,998	7,607	3,589

[6] Further statistics on teachers availing of career break are published by the Department of Education and Youth each year, and are available to view here.

Geographic breakdown

The following section breaks down the headline statistics in Table 1 to county level. Table 8 provides the summary by county for primary level based on November data. Table 9 provides the summary by county for secondary, community & comprehensive post primary. Due to the fact that teachers may be shared between schools within each ETB, it is not appropriate to provide a summary at county level for ETB vocational post primary schools. As such, Table 10 provides the summary by ETB for ETB vocational post primary. Figures 3, 4 and 5 below map these data to illustrate the spatial patterns of cover.

Table 8 - Primary FTE by County, November 2025 – Mainstream Schools

County	Allocated FTE	Payroll FTE	Difference	Cover (%)
Carlow	557.0	543.0	-14.0	97.5
Cavan	704.0	693.1	-10.9	98.5
Clare	989.0	968.2	-20.8	97.9
Cork	4,689.5	4,566.4	-123.1	97.4
Donegal	1,434.4	1,411.4	-23.0	98.4
Dublin	10,067.5	9,744.6	-322.9	96.8
Galway	2,272.0	2,223.2	-48.8	97.9
Kerry	1,201.5	1,187.7	-13.8	98.9
Kildare	1,956.0	1,883.3	-72.7	96.3
Kilkenny	713.0	700.2	-12.8	98.2
Laois	824.0	804.7	-19.3	97.7
Leitrim	282.0	279.4	-2.6	99.1
Limerick	1,756.5	1,739.2	-17.3	99.0
Longford	427.0	415.6	-11.4	97.3
Louth	1,253.0	1,238.6	-14.4	98.9
Mayo	1,122.0	1,104.7	-17.3	98.5
Meath	1,755.0	1,706.9	-48.1	97.3
Monaghan	567.0	545.2	-21.8	96.2
Offaly	777.0	760.4	-16.6	97.9
Roscommon	619.0	606.0	-13.0	97.9
Sligo	526.0	511.5	-14.5	97.2
Tipperary	1,405.0	1,375.1	-29.9	97.9
Waterford	1,009.0	987.5	-21.5	97.9
Westmeath	836.0	813.9	-22.1	97.4
Wexford	1,330.0	1,307.0	-23.0	98.3
Wicklow	1,236.0	1,195.5	-40.5	96.7

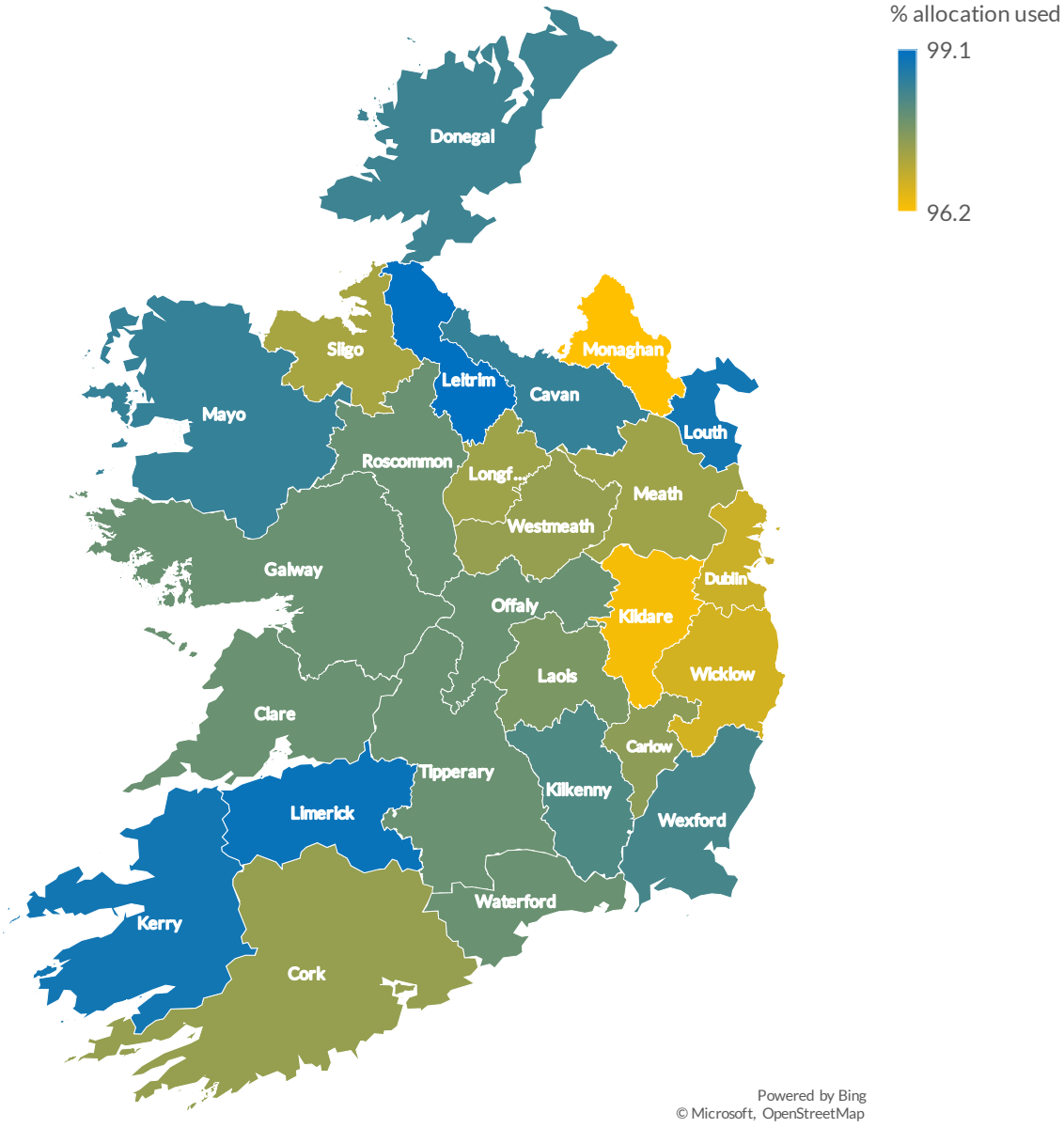


Figure 3 - Primary percentage of allocated posts used by county, November 2025

Table 9 – Post Primary Secondary, Community & Comprehensive FTE by County, November 2025

County	Allocated FTE	Payroll FTE	Difference	Cover (%)
Carlow	326.7	326.8	0.1	100
Cavan	296.4	290.7	-5.8	98.1
Clare	556.7	546.7	-9.9	98.2
Cork	2,833.4	2,793.7	-39.7	98.6
Donegal	744.0	719.2	-24.8	96.7
Dublin	6,191.7	6,075.7	-116.0	98.1
Galway	1,419.1	1,399.9	-19.2	98.6
Kerry	779.4	764.9	-14.5	98.1
Kildare	1,033.6	1,021.2	-12.3	98.8
Kilkenny	425.4	423.8	-1.6	99.6
Laois	405.8	401.2	-4.5	98.9
Leitrim	122.8	122.5	-0.3	99.8
Limerick	846.7	840.8	-5.8	99.3
Longford	252.2	248.4	-3.9	98.5
Louth	794.8	782.4	-12.3	98.4
Mayo	743.8	729.2	-14.6	98.0
Meath	637.3	624.0	-13.3	97.9
Monaghan	239.3	236.8	-2.5	98.9
Offaly	360.5	353.8	-6.7	98.1
Roscommon	305.7	301.5	-4.2	98.6
Sligo	354.0	348.2	-5.8	98.4
Tipperary	810.2	801.1	-9.0	98.9
Waterford	660.9	646.8	-14.1	97.9
Westmeath	557.3	548.5	-8.9	98.4
Wexford	838.2	821.2	-17.1	98.0
Wicklow	594.9	579.6	-15.4	97.4

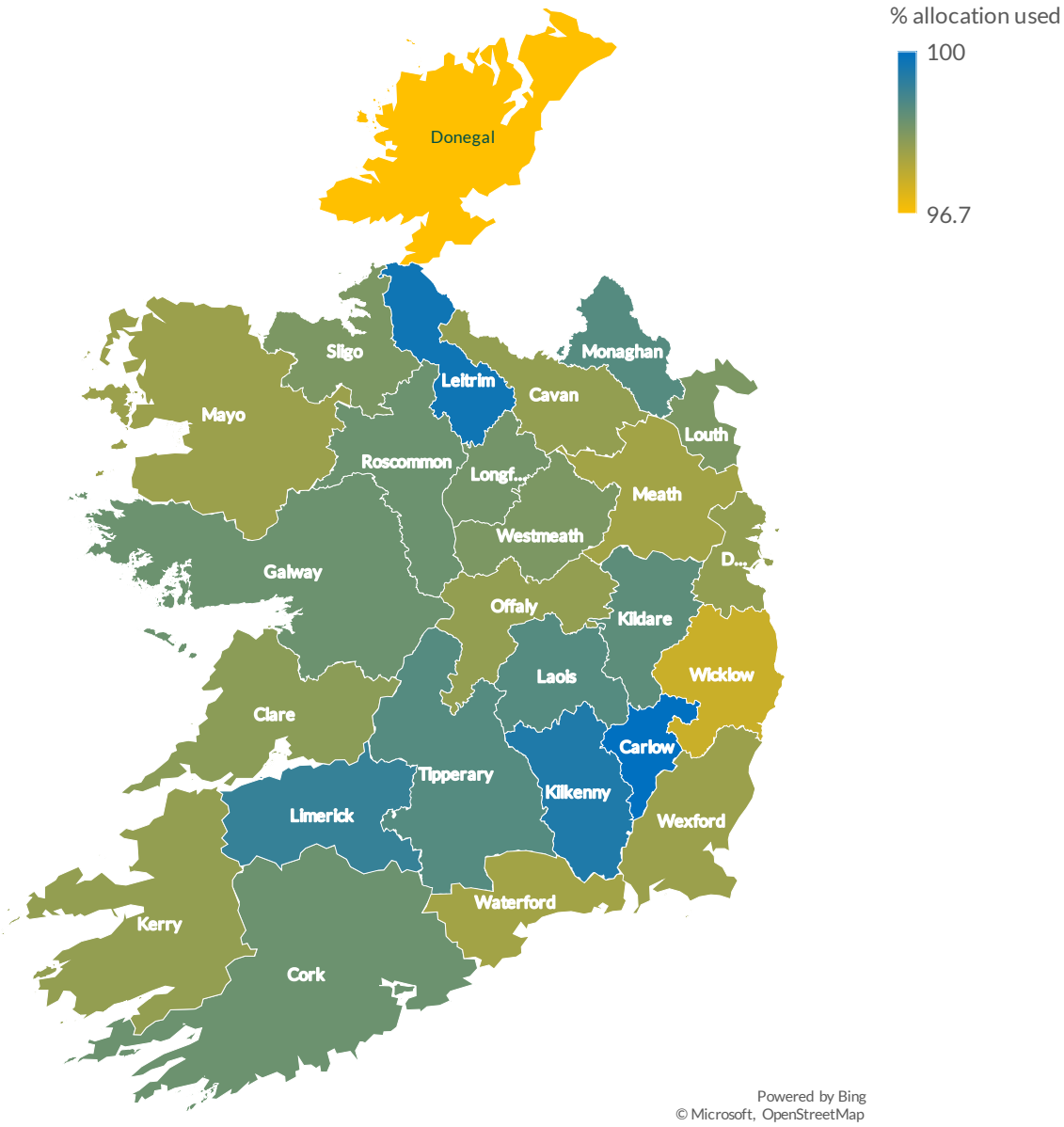


Figure 4- Percentage of allocated posts used by county for secondary, community & comprehensive post primary, November 2025

Table 10 – Post Primary Vocational FTE by ETB, November 2025

ETB	Allocated FTE	Payroll FTE	Difference	Cover (%)
Cavan & Monaghan	525.1	525.9	0.8	100
City Of Dublin	376.1	411.8	35.7	100
Cork	1,323.1	1,295.1	-28.0	97.9
Donegal	576.6	564.1	-12.5	97.8
Dublin & Dun Laoghaire	1,758.9	1,832.8	73.9	100
Galway & Roscommon	693.9	721.5	27.6	100
Kerry	308.0	302.3	-5.7	98.1
Kildare & Wicklow	1,297.7	1326.0	28.3	100
Kilkenny & Carlow	477.9	479.0	1.1	100
Laois & Offaly	436.6	415.6	-21.0	95.2
Limerick & Clare	852.8	850.3	-2.6	99.7
Longford & Westmeath	334.2	359.5	25.3	100
Louth & Meath	1,187.5	1,185.3	-2.2	99.8
Mayo, Sligo & Leitrim	517.4	502.8	-14.7	97.2
Tipperary	512.2	516.1	3.9	100
Waterford & Wexford	564.4	589.3	24.9	100

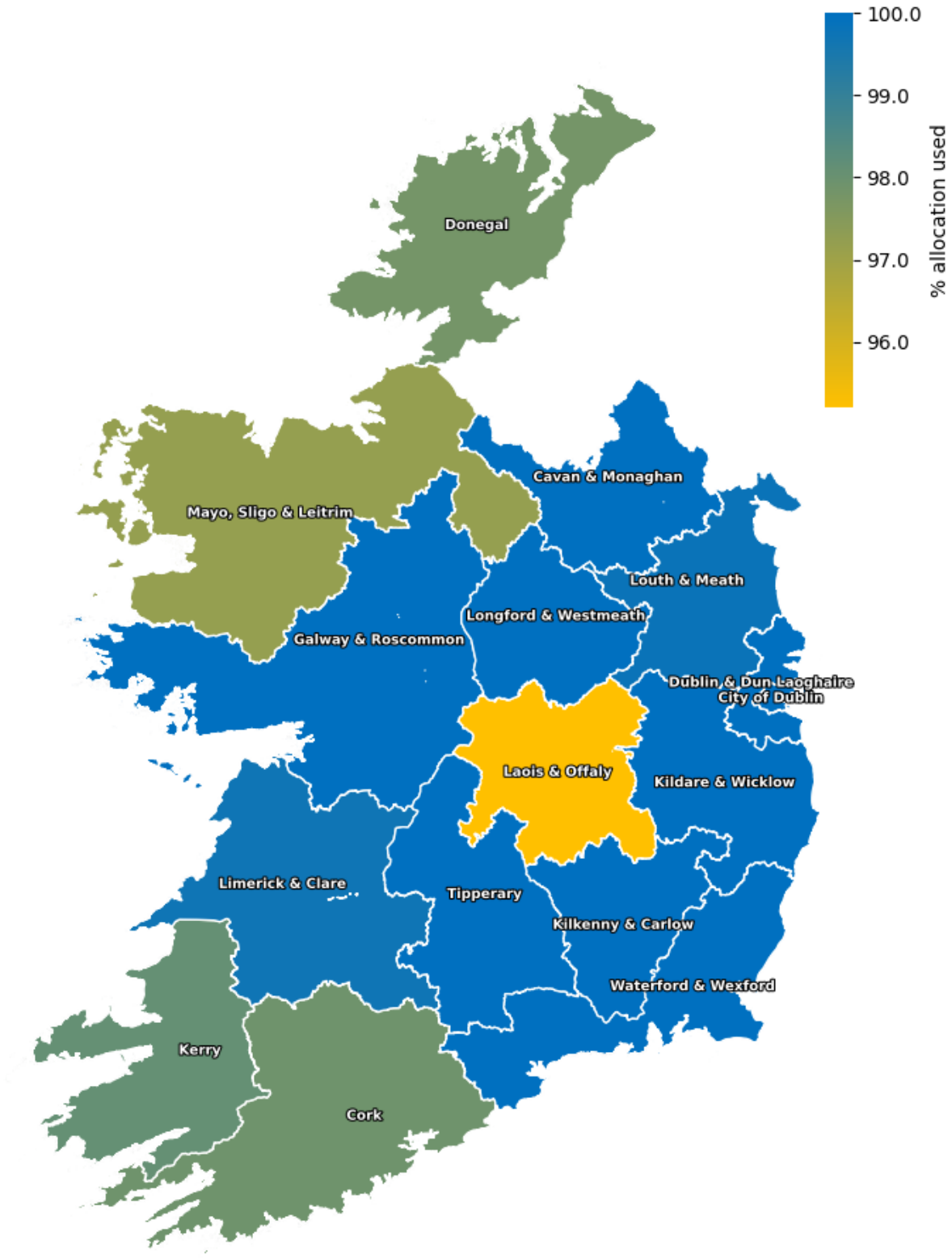


Figure 5 - Percentage of allocated posts used by Education Training Board, November 2025

Appendix A - Secondary data for statistical production

This section provides a brief discussion around statistical production and how it was carried out for this report. The Generic Statistical Business Process Model (GSBPM) describes and defines the set of business processes needed to produce official statistics and provides an overarching methodological approach. It provides a standard framework and harmonised terminology to help organisations to modernise their statistical production processes, as well as to share methods and components – see **Figure 5** below). The GSBPM is agnostic to the specific statistical output and input data / collection methods, therefore can be tailored to specific use cases. However, as noted in the figure below, a significant proportion of the production model is dedicated to building collection instruments and in the collection of data itself. In general, statistical production can streamline the production process by reusing data that are already available, provided they are fit for purpose, this approach of using so called "secondary" data for statistical production was adopted for the purposes of this report.

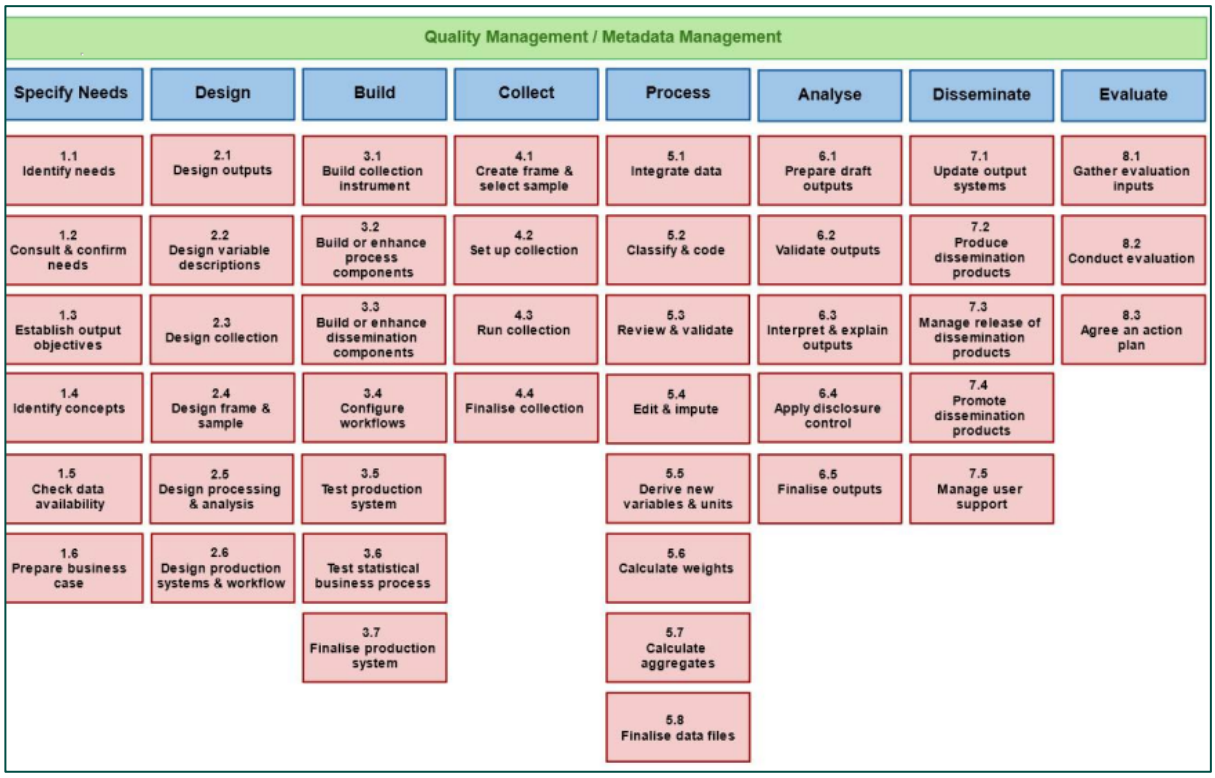


Figure 5- The Generic Statistical Business Process Model for statistical production.

Utilising secondary data in this way is a strategic approach in statistical analysis, leveraging existing information for various components of the GSBPM.

For clarity, "Secondary data" refers to data collected by others for different objectives but repurposed for statistical production, in this case, reusing information generated in the payment of teaching staff to generate statistical information on the overall workforce. The choice of this approach over primary data includes (but are not limited to):

- **Cost-Efficiency:** Utilising existing secondary data reduces costs associated with primary data collection, saving both time and financial resources.

- **Timesaving:** Researchers can swiftly access and analyse secondary data, bypassing the lengthy process of gathering information themselves.
- **Broad Scope:** Secondary data often covers extensive periods, diverse geographical areas, or various demographics, providing a more comprehensive view rather than what a population sample can yield.
- **Historical Analysis**: It allows for historical comparisons, facilitating trend analyses and longitudinal studies (time-series analysis)
- **Supplementary Insights:** Secondary data can supplement/validate primary data, enriching research findings, supporting deeper analysis and providing a stronger evidence base.

The main drawbacks of this approach (speaking generally) relate to the reliability and accuracy of secondary data, the limited amount of control over data collection procedures, compatibility with research aims.

However, specific to this use report, the payroll systems used in the payment of the workforce are sufficiently mature to ensure there is little/no errors of commission or omission, in short, all those in receipt of payment can be said to be active in the teaching profession, therefore it was deemed this would be a robust and comprehensive source of information.

Nevertheless, careful consideration and development was required to align the different underlying data models / concepts (as two separate payroll systems are utilised in this report) and to ensure the statistical concepts required were satisfied by these data. These concepts are outlined in the next section of this report.

Appendix B - Key Concepts

For this report, several key concepts arise out of the use of payroll data for statistical production, these are outlined in this section. For ease of use, each concept is highlighted below, with an explanation of how it is defined, how it is measured and ultimately presented in this report. Many concepts are not independent of one another, but rather interact, for example, “Full Time Equivalency” informs the “Mean Conversion Rate”.

Concept 1: Teaching Workforce

Definition: The teaching workforce refers to staff employed to work within schools at primary and post primary level, the provision/allocation of which is sanctioned by the Department of Education, and therefore the post is paid by either the Department of Education and/or The Education Training Boards (ETBs). This includes most categories of staff that are employed within a school to plan/deliver teaching to students, and includes teaching staff, school leaders, support staff, temporary teaching staff and so forth. In general, this only excludes school maintenance staff and administrative

staff who also appear on payroll data. This concept also excludes staff that are wholly employed by private schools, as these posts are not allocated/paid by either the Department or ETBs.
Measurement: Recipients of payments from either the Department or ETBs are included as part of the teaching workforce, provided they paid for employment allocated by the Department (at either primary or post primary level) and/or meet one of the concepts below.

Concept 2: Teachers and Teaching staff

Definition: A teacher is anyone whose staff grade / job description on payroll associates them as engaging with teaching (e.g. Classroom Teacher, Special Duties Teacher) and whose cost centre / employer is a **primary or post primary school**. While a record may be described as a "post primary teacher" if they are employed by one of the further education and training centres (FET) they are **not** included in the teaching workforce as their role is allocated outside of a recognised primary / post primary school.
Measurement: Job description matches the broad description of teacher, and the employer is a recognised primary or post primary School

Concept 3: Special Needs Assistants

Definition: A special needs assistant is anyone whose staff grade / job description on payroll associates them as being employed by a recognised school as a special needs assistant – i.e. a school in which the department makes an allocation of posts for special needs assistants.
Measurement: Job description matches the broad description of special needs assistant, and the employer is a recognised Primary or Post Primary School

Concept 4: Substitute Teachers

Definition: A substitute teacher is anyone whose staff grade / job description on payroll associates them as being employed by a recognised school with teaching or supervision duties, and for which they received a payment separately from any core salary (i.e. claimed). This excludes any "core" or "permanent" teachers who provide substitution in addition to their main teaching duties, and explicitly only includes staff who pay is "claimed" for
Measurement: Job description matches the broad description of substitute teacher, are paid via claims/causal pay (non-contracted), and the employer is a recognised primary or post primary school

Concept 5: Full time equivalence versus head counts

Definition: FTE (full-time equivalent) and headcount are both methods used to measure the workforce in this report. The key difference is that FTE refers to the number of full-time hours being worked, while headcount for each school is the number of unique employees present on payroll. This means if a teacher works across two schools in two different counties, they are counted toward the head count of each county they work (i.e. they are counted twice). FTE is calculated using the pro-rated payment on payroll based on a full time contract. So, if a teacher rate of pay is the same for a teacher working 22 hours, they are counted as 1 FTE. If a teacher is paid for 11 hours, they are

counted as 0.5 FTE. If two teachers in the same roll number are paid each for 11 hours, they are counted as 1 FTE for the school – and so forth.

Measurement: *FTE* is calculated using the payment made, pro-rated based on salary and a full contract payment (i.e. working 22 hours per week), headcount is calculated using a unique pseudonymised identifier.

Concept 6: Leave, absences

Definition: **Absences and leave** are those pseudonymised identifiers that appear in claims systems data, whether their leave/absence is substitutable or non-substitutable or paid/unpaid.

Measurement: Count of unique pseudonymised identifiers that appear in claims systems.

Concept 7: Mean Conversion Rate

Definition: **The Conversion Rate** reflects the pattern of work an individual undertakes compared to a stated/known maximum which should equal 1 FTE (as defined above). For example, if an individual works 20 hours per week where the maximum for a given organisations employees is 40 hours per week, the conversion rate is 50%, if they worked 30 hours of a potential 40, the conversion rate would be 75%, if they worked 40 hours, the conversion rate would be 100%. Lower conversion rates mean more individuals are required to fill a position. This creates additional overhead for HR/administrators within an organisation, therefore is a key measure within workforce management.

Measurement: The mean conversion rate (MCR) rather than individual conversion rates are derived and reported. MCR is derived by summing the total hours worked by all employees (based on FTE and contract hours) and dividing that by the total maximum hours that number of employees could yield.

